result of a superstition that magnetic lodestones in the sea would suck in ships with iron-nails, but this is a very unlikely explanation. More likely, it was a response to the fact that these ships sailed in waters full of atolls and reefs, and had to be beached in many places due to the lack of sheltered harbours or due to the rough monsoon sea. All this required a hull that was a bit flexible and would not break-up easily. The stitched technique provided this flexibility although it would later limit the ability of Indian ship-building to match Chinese and then European design innovations.

So, how did it feel to sail in these ships? A Chinese scholar Fa Xian (also spelled Fa Hien) visited India in the fifth century and has left us a fascinating account of his return journey by the sea route.[14] Fa Xian came to India by the land route through Central Asia. He spent several years in northern India studying and gathering Buddhist texts. He then made his way to the port of Tamralipti. The site of this famous port of antiquity, now called Tamluk, is not far from modern Kolkata. It is close to where the Rupnarayan river joins the Gangetic delta, but the old channel that served the port has silted up and is no longer navigable. Except for a 1200-year-old temple dedicated to the goddess Kali, there is little there to hint at a glorious past as a successful hub of commerce. Indeed, Tamluk is close to the infamous village of Nandigram where a dispute over land acquisition in 2007 led to a bloody clash between the state government and locals that left scores dead. It is now considered a hotbed of Maoist rebels.

In 410 AD, however, Fa Xian would have found a port town bustling with activity. He tells us that he boarded a large merchant ship bound for Sri Lanka. The voyage was during the winter months when the monsoons winds would have been blowing south. The ship sailed in a south-westerly direction for just fourteen days before arriving in Sri Lanka. Fa Xian calls it the Land of the Lions—a clear reference to the mythical origins of the Sinhalese people (there were never any real lions in Sri Lanka).

The Chinese scholar spent two years in Sri Lanka studying Buddhist texts before setting sail for South East Asia. He tells us that it was a large vessel that could carry two hundred people. It was accompanied by a smaller ship that carried extra provisions and could help in an emergency. Unfortunately,